

For Participants

Everything you need to know before and during the session

What to bring

A real piece of code you're working on. It doesn't need to be:

- Finished
- Working correctly
- Well-organised
- In a language your partner knows

If you're not sure what to bring, pick a script you run regularly. There's almost always something to improve, explain, or make clearer.

The two roles

Driver — controls the keyboard and types. Focuses on the immediate task: writing, reading, and editing code.

Navigator — watches, thinks ahead, and asks questions. Focuses on the bigger picture: does this approach make sense, are there edge cases, what should happen next?

Switch roles regularly — every 10–15 minutes, or when you reach a natural pause.

Before you start each round

- Give your partner a 2-minute tour of your code: what does it do, what are you working on, where are you stuck?
- Agree who drives first

While you're pairing

If you're the driver

- Talk through what you're doing as you type
- Ask the navigator before making big changes
- Don't feel you have to type quickly — thinking out loud matters more

If you're the navigator

- Ask questions freely — “what does this variable hold?”
- Don’t grab the keyboard; say what you’d try and let the driver type it
- Watch for typos and logic errors the driver might miss

Both of you

- It’s fine not to solve the problem — the conversation is the point
- Messy, unfinished code is normal and expected; no judgement
- If you’re stuck, say so — “I have no idea what this does” is a useful thing to say

Things that often come up in sessions

- A tool or library your partner uses that you haven’t seen before
- A different way of approaching a problem you’ve been stuck on
- Something you’ve been doing for years that turns out to have a neater solution
- A bug that you spotted the moment you had to explain the code out loud

Making it a regular practice

A one-off session is a good introduction — but pairing works best as a habit, not an event.

A few things worth trying after today:

- **Find a buddy for your next project**, not just your current one. The best time to pair is at the very start, when you’re making structural decisions that are hard to change later.
- **Pair with someone different each time**. A collaborator in a different lab, someone who uses a different language or tool, someone at a very different experience level — each pairing teaches you something the last one didn’t.
- **Even occasional pairing helps**. You don’t need to pair on every line of code. A 30-minute session at the start of a new analysis, or when you’re stuck on something, is enough to get real value.

If you’d like to be matched with a new pairing partner outside of organised events, [get in touch](#).

Further reading and watching

- [On Pair Programming](#) — the most thorough practical guide available. Worth reading if you want to go deeper on techniques and common objections.
- [Scientific research into pair programming](#) — a readable summary of the empirical evidence, if you want to convince a sceptical colleague.
- [All About Pair Programming \(AMA\)](#) — Ben Orenstein answers common questions in a live Q&A. Good background watch.